True Nature—Awake Awareness #1

Guided Reflection: Who Am I?

The fundamental question in most spiritual traditions is "Who am I?" The formal practice of self-inquiry is a powerful way of seeing beyond our stories of self and revealing the mystery of our true nature.

Before exploring the following meditation, take some time relaxing and quieting the mind. While thoughts and emotions will naturally continue to arise during this meditation, it is best initiated when emotions are not intense.

If you would like to explore practicing with your eyes open, try to find a setting where you can look directly at the open sky or at a view that is not distracting. It is also fine to look out a window, at a blank wall, or at the open space of a room.

Sit comfortably in a way that allows you to feel both alert and relaxed. If your eyes are open, rest your gaze on a point slightly above your line of sight. Soften your eyes so that your gaze is unfocused and you are also receiving images on the periphery of your vision. Relax the flesh around your eyes and let your brow be smooth.

Looking at the sky or imagining a clear blue sky, let your awareness mingle with that boundless space. Allow your mind to be wide open—relaxed and spacious. Take some moments to listen to sounds, noticing how they are happening on their own. Rest in the awareness that includes even the most distant sounds.

In the same way that sounds are appearing and disappearing, allow sensations and emotions to arise and dissolve. Let your breath move easily, like a gentle breeze. Be aware of thoughts drifting through like passing clouds. Rest in an open and undistracted awareness, and with a receptive attention. Notice the changing display of sounds, sensations, feelings, thoughts.

As the mind rests in this listening attention, inquire, "Who is aware right now?"or, "Who is listening?" You might instead ask, "What is aware right now?" or, "What is listening?" Glance back into awareness with interest and a light touch—simply taking a look to see what is true.

What do you notice? Is there any "thing" or "self" you perceive that is static, solid, or enduring? Is there an entity that exists apart from the changing stream of feelings, sensations, or thoughts? What actually do you see when you look into awareness? Is there any boundary or center to your experience? Are you aware of being aware?

After you have looked back into awareness, let go and relax fully into the sea of wakefulness. Let go and let be, allowing life to unfold naturally in awareness. Rest in non-doing, in undistracted awareness.

Continue to rest in awareness until the mind again focuses on a sound or sensation or some other experience. When you realize your mind has fixated on a particular thought—on a judgment or mental comment, an image or story—gently look into awareness to recognize the source of thinking. Inquire: "Who is thinking?" Or you might ask, "What is thinking?" or, "Who is aware right now?" Glance back into awareness with a light touch, simply taking a look to see who is thinking.

Then let go and relax fully into whatever you see. Let go and let be, allowing life to unfold naturally in awareness. Rest in non-doing, in undistracted awareness. With each instance of releasing the grip of thoughts, be sure to relax completely. Discover the freedom of wakefully relaxing, of letting life be as it is. Look and see, let go and be free.

If sensations or emotions call your attention, look back into awareness in the same way, asking who is feeling hot or tired or afraid. However, if they are in any way strong or compelling, instead of turning toward awareness, bring an accepting and kind attention directly to the experience. You might feel the grip of fear, for instance, and use the breath to reconnect with openness and tenderness. When you are able to relate to your experience with equanimity and compassion again, resume the practice of resting in awareness and inquiry.

If at any point you find the mind has become distracted, reopen your attention to the senses—listening to sounds, feeling sensations. Then as you settle into mindful presence, continue to inquire into the awareness that is behind all experience.

As you choose, you might weave in a similar practice to active inquiry: Say or think, "I am," and add nothing to it. Be aware of the silence and stillness that follows the words. Sense your presence, your pure uncontrived beingness. Let go and be that presence.

It is important that we practice self-inquiry in an easy and effortless way, not contracting the mind by striving to do it right. To avoid creating stress, it is best to limit practice to five- to ten-minute intervals. You might do short periods of formal practice a number of times a day.

As an informal practice take a few moments whenever you remember to look into awareness and see what is true. Then let go and let be. In time, the trance of a separate self will become increasingly apparent, and you'll begin to realize the empty radiance of awareness that is your true home.

Guided Reflection: Taking the Backward Step

Our natural awareness is revealed when we stop struggling to control or manipulate our attention. This meditation offers a seeming paradox: We intentionally let go of any purposeful doing. While this itself is a subtle kind of doing, with continued practice, letting go begins to occur spontaneously whenever we recognize the tension of controlling.

Before beginning, you might practice "Exploring Inner Space," or some other meditation that helps you settle, quiet your mind, and relax.

Find a posture that is upright and comfortable and come into stillness. If possible, let go of any seeking, any struggle, any goals. Now allow yourself to enter the receptive state of listening. Listen in all directions, near and far, not fixing on any particular sound, taking everything in evenly. Explore listening not just with your ears, but with your whole awareness—listening to sounds, to sensations, to breathing.

In this receptive state, let life be just as it is. Check in with your body, and if you find tension, recognize it as a sign of resistance to letting go. Simply note the tension and allow it to be as it is. If there is restlessness, allow it to be as it is.

Awareness is fluid; it recognizes different experiences without directing or resisting. Imagine yourself as a passenger in a car, aware of experience as it arises and passes, like the view out your window. You are not in control. You have no idea of what should happen, of where you are going. You are just noticing and allowing. You are being awareness.

If thoughts arise, simply note, "This is just a thought." Let go, return to now, to presence. If you find the mind trying to interpret or direct the meditation, let go. Sometimes mentally whispering "drop" can help the mind release what it's holding on to.

Once you have opened out of a thought, take some moments to notice the difference between any thought and the vividness and mystery of the here and now.

You may find that you've let go of thoughts and are focusing on the sounds, feelings, or sensations in the foreground of your experience. Explore what happens when you let go yet again, and sense the background of experience, your own presence. You can't see or hear or locate this presence, yet you can relax back into this formless dimension of being.

When you take the backward step and surrender into presence, a silent spaciousness enters awareness. The silence is listening to sounds, to thoughts. A great stillness receives the experience of aliveness. Everything is happening in wakeful openness. Simply rest in this open space of awareness, continuing to allow the sounds and feelings of life to flow through.

As your meditation practice deepens, it is valuable to spend at least part of your practice time letting go of all controlling, relaxing back and resting in an open, allowing awareness.

Cultivating an Open-Focused Awareness

(language adapted from the work of Les Fehmi)

Training your attention with a non-object focus enhances your mental flexibility, relieves stress and gives you insight into the nature of awareness itself.

Find a posture for sitting or standing that is gently erect, and that you can maintain without moving, if possible. Close your eyes and after each question, take a few moments to notice whatever spontaneously arises.

Can you imagine listening to sounds and sensing the open space they are happening in?

Can you imagine that this open space is also filling your mind?

Can you imagine the space between your eyes?

Can you imagine the breath flowing behind your eyes as you inhale naturally?

Can you imagine the space inside your nose as you inhale and exhale naturally?

Can you imagine the space inside your throat as you inhale naturally?

Can you imagine the volume of your tongue—the space your tongue occupies?

Can you imagine the space your teeth and gums occupy?

Can you imagine the volume of your lips?

Can you imagine the entire space inside your mouth and cheeks?

Can you imagine the space between your ears?

Can you imagine the distance between your forehead and the back of your skull?

Can you imagine that as you inhale naturally, your breath fills the entire volume of your face, scalp, and head?

Can you imagine that as you exhale your entire head is filled with space?

Can you imagine the space inside your throat expanding until your entire neck is filled with space?

Can you imagine the space inside your shoulders?

Can you imagine the space between your shoulders?

Can you imagine that as you inhale the breath fills the entire area of the shoulders?

Can you imagine that as you exhale, the shoulders and space between them are filled with space?

Can you imagine the distance between the shoulders and the elbows?

Can you imagine the distance between the elbows and the wrists?

Can you imagine the volume the thumbs occupy?

Can you imagine the space between the thumb and index fingers?

Can you imagine the space occupied by the middle fingers?

Can you imagine the space occupied by the ring fingers?

Can you imagine the space occupied by the little fingers?

Can you imagine the space between all the fingers?

Can you imagine the space between the palm and back of your hands?

Can you imagine that as you inhale, breath fills the hands?

Can you imagine that as you exhale, the hands are filled with space?

Can you imagine the space inside the hands, arms and shoulders?

Can you imagine the distance between your breastbone and spinal column?

Can you imagine the distance between the sides of the chest?

Can you imagine the volume the heart occupies?

Can you imagine the volume the lungs occupy?

Can you imagine the space inside the entire chest, including the heart and lungs?

Can you imagine the region between your navel and your backbone is filled with space?

Can you imagine the space between both sides of your waist?

Can you imagine the region between your navel and your tailbone is filled with space?

Can you imagine the entire belly is filled with space?

Can you imagine the distance between your hips and your knees?

Can you imagine the distance between your knees and your ankles?

Can you imagine the space between all your toes?

Can you imagine the space between the soles of your feet and the tops of your feet?

Can you imagine the space that fills your toes and your feet?

Can you imagine the space that extends from the feet deep into the earth?

Can you imagine that as you inhale your breath fills your entire body?

Can you imagine that as you exhale, your entire body is filled with space?

Can you imagine the space in front of your body extending out infinitely?

Can you imagine the space behind your body extending out infinitely?

Can you imagine the space to either side of your body extending out infinitely?

Can you imagine the space above you extending infinitely?

Can you imagine that the space around you and the space within you are continuous?

Can you imagine that this space is awake and alive?

Can you imagine that this space is filled with the light of awareness?

Can you imagine resting in the awareness of continuous space?

Can you imagine moving through your day and remembering to notice the space within and around you?